

Emphatic and Stylistic Structures

C1 · Renan the Teacher — English Language Academy

1. BRIEF EXPLANATION

Cleft sentences split one idea into two clauses to put spotlight on a specific piece of information. They are a hallmark of fluent, natural-sounding advanced English.

- a) It-clefts — "It is/was + the emphasized element + who/that + rest of the sentence." Used to highlight a subject, object, time or place.

Neutral: Sarah broke the vase.

Emphasized: It was Sarah who broke the vase. (emphasis on who did it)

It was the vase that Sarah broke. (emphasis on what was broken)

It was yesterday that Sarah broke the vase. (emphasis on when)

- b) Pseudo-clefts (wh-clefts) — start with a wh-word (what, where, why, how, the thing/reason/place that...) + be + the emphasized element. Used to highlight an action, reason, or entire idea, often at the end for maximum impact.

What I found surprising was his reaction. (= His reaction was what I found surprising.)

What bothers me most is his constant lateness.

The thing that annoys me is his tone.

Where we went wrong was underestimating the competition.

- c) All-cleft (a variation): All + relative clause + is/was + emphasized element, used to minimize/emphasize simplicity.

All I want is a bit of peace and quiet.

Use clefts to control which part of a sentence the listener/reader focuses on — a key stylistic tool in speeches, essays, and persuasive writing.

2. EXAMPLES

- 1. It was her honesty that impressed the interviewers most.
- 2. It is the lack of funding that's holding the project back.
- 3. What surprised me most was how calm she stayed.
- 4. What we need now is a clear plan of action.
- 5. It was in Lisbon that they first met.
- 6. The reason I called was to check on you.
- 7. What annoys me is when people interrupt.

- 8. It was not the money but the recognition that motivated him.
- 9. All she wants is a bit of appreciation for her work.
- 10. What made the difference was their attention to detail.
- 11. It was only after the accident that he changed his habits.
- 12. Where the plan failed was in its complete lack of funding.

3. COMMON MISTAKES

- 1. Incorrect: It was Sarah that broke who the vase.

Correct: It was Sarah who broke the vase.

Why: Choose either "who" (for people) or "that," and place it right after the emphasized element — don't split or double it.

- 2. Incorrect: What I found it surprising was his reaction.

Correct: What I found surprising was his reaction.

Why: Don't add a redundant object pronoun ("it") — the wh-clause already functions as the subject.

- 3. Incorrect: What bothers me most it's his constant lateness.

Correct: What bothers me most is his constant lateness.

Why: Use "is/was" directly, not a contracted "it's," which duplicates the subject.

- 4. Incorrect: It was her the one who impressed the interviewers.

Correct: It was her/she who impressed the interviewers. / She was the one who impressed the interviewers.

Why: Don't mix the it-cleft and the "the one who" structure in the same sentence — pick one pattern.

- 5. Incorrect: All what I want is some peace and quiet.

Correct: All I want is some peace and quiet.

Why: "All" already functions like "the only thing that," so don't add "what" as well.

4. EXERCISES

- A. Gap-fill (complete the cleft sentence)
- 1. It ___ my brother who fixed the car, not me.
- 2. What really impressed the judges ___ her confidence on stage.
- 3. It was ___ the noise, not the crowd, that bothered him most.
- 4. The reason she left early ___ to catch her flight.
- 5. All he wants ___ a quiet place to work.
- 6. It was only when I moved abroad ___ I understood my parents better.
- 7. What we should focus on ___ the customer experience, not just the price.

- 8. It ____ during the interview, not the written test, that he stood out.
- B. Rewrite / Transformation (rewrite each sentence as a cleft sentence, emphasizing the underlined part)
 - 1. Her attitude, not her skills, worried the manager. (it-cleft)
 - 2. I really admire his patience. (pseudo-cleft with "What")
 - 3. We met in Barcelona, not Madrid. (it-cleft)
 - 4. She wants nothing more than some recognition. (all-cleft)
 - 5. His lack of preparation caused the failure. (pseudo-cleft with "What")
 - 6. I called to apologize, not to argue. (it-cleft, emphasizing the reason)
- C. Error Correction
 - 1. It was John that he lost the keys.
 - 2. What I need it is more time.
 - 3. All what matters to her is her family.
 - 4. It the manager was who approved the budget.
 - 5. What surprised us it was the ending of the film.
 - 6. It was not the price the thing that bothered me.
- D. Guided Production
 - 1. Write one it-cleft sentence emphasizing who did something.
 - 2. Write one pseudo-cleft sentence starting with "What..." about something that matters to you.
 - 3. Write one it-cleft sentence emphasizing when or where something happened.
 - 4. Write one all-cleft sentence ("All I want/need is...").

5. ANSWER KEY

- A. Gap-fill
 - 1. was
 - 2. was
 - 3. the noise
 - 4. was
 - 5. is
 - 6. that
 - 7. is
 - 8. was
- B. Rewrite / Transformation
 - 1. It was her attitude, not her skills, that worried the manager.
 - 2. What I really admire is his patience.
 - 3. It was in Barcelona, not Madrid, that we met.
 - 4. All she wants is some recognition.
 - 5. What caused the failure was his lack of preparation.
 - 6. It was to apologize, not to argue, that I called.
- C. Error Correction
 - 1. It was John who lost the keys.
 - 2. What I need is more time.
 - 3. All that matters to her is her family.
 - 4. It was the manager who approved the budget.
 - 5. What surprised us was the ending of the film.
 - 6. It was not the price but the way it was handled that bothered me.
- D. Guided Production (sample answers)
 - 1. It was my grandmother who taught me how to cook.
 - 2. What matters most to me is spending time with the people I love.
 - 3. It was on a rainy afternoon in Porto that I fell in love with the city.

- 4. All I need is a strong cup of coffee to start my day.

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